Business Communication
BCOM 231
Syllabus – Spring 2026

Faculty Information

Dr. Cristina Gilstrap
Associate Professor, Business Communication
Romain College of Business
Email: cgilstrap@usi.edu
Office: BE 2081
Office Hours: Tuesdays/Thursdays, 8:00 – 8:30 AM, 12:00 – 1:00 PM or By Appointment

Romain College of Business Social Media

Follow the College's social media for internship, student organization, study abroad, professional development, academic, and scholarship announcements, events, and contests.

	https://www.usi.edu/business/
	@usircob
	USI Romain College of Business
	usircob

Romain College of Business AACSB Accreditation

The Romain College of Business is accredited by the Association to Advance Collegiate Schools of Business (AACSB) for its undergraduate and graduate programs, including a supplemental accreditation for our accounting program. Only 1,013 business schools in 60 countries and territories have earned AACSB accreditation, and 194 business schools hold dual AACSB accreditation in business and accounting. AACSB accreditation recognizes RCOB's commitment to ongoing excellence in teaching, research, curriculum development, and student learning. For additional student AACSB information/resources visit https://www.aacsb.edu/learners.

Course Information

Credit Hours: 3
Meeting Location: BE 2005
Pre-requisites: CMST 101 and ENG 201
Course Mode: In-Person (technology enhanced)

Course Description

A detailed study of business communication. Includes analysis and practice in writing a variety of messages used to communicate in business and industry. Emphasizes the linguistic and behavioral aspects of effective organizational communication.

Course Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, students should be able to:

- create a professional, public-facing business message
- compose effective business correspondence
- develop a persuasive application packet
- compose professional deliverables in APA format
- deliver an effective business presentation with accompanying visuals

Program Learning Objectives

As a CORE 39 writing-intensive embedded experience course:

- writing assignments will be integrated throughout the semester
- writing assignments will constitute a significant portion of the course grade
- class lectures/exercises and the textbook will include lessons on effective business communication
- students will compose one sustained/long-term writing project that (a) synthesizes the major objectives of the course, (b) provides instructor feedback on student drafts, and (c) includes opportunities for revision
- acceptable writing style criteria will be taught in the course and outlined in course assignments

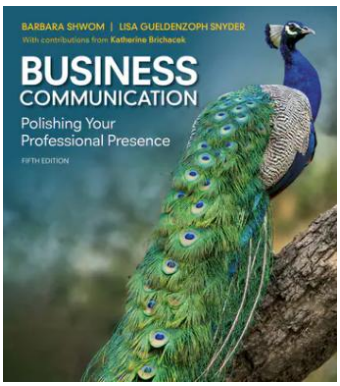
Romain College of Business Skill Development

BCOM 231 helps meet oral and written communication skill requirements for the Romain College of Business.

Required Textbook and Technology

Textbook (required)

Shwom, B., & Snyder, L. G. (2025). *Business communication: Polishing your professional presence* (5th ed.). Pearson.



ISBN-13: 9780138189822
Available at USI Campus Store

*You must rent/purchase the **5th edition** of the textbook*

Grammarly Pro (required)

- Grammarly Pro (*do not purchase your semester subscription until assigned in class)

Technology (required)

- Microsoft Word (go to https://www.usi.edu/it/microsoft-365email for directions to download Microsoft Office 365 for free as a USI student)
  (NOTE – Google Docs will NOT work for our class requirements)
- high-speed/reliable Internet connection (e.g., DSL or Cable).
- microphone and webcam (for online exam proctoring and live Zoom classes/team meetings)

Chrome Browser (required)
As posted on MyUSI and USI's IT website, the required browser for Blackboard and Honorlock is:

Google Chrome

Assignments, Testing, and Grading Scale

As a required business core course, you must pass BCOM 231 to graduate.

Assignments and Testing

Assignment	Points
Chapter Quizzes	60
Exam 1	80
Exam 2	80
USI Internship & Career Fair Participation	30
APA Mastery Exam	100
Application Assignment I	50
Application Assignment II	75
Text Analytics Project	75
Homework/Online Lectures	100
TOTAL	**650 points***

** I reserve the right to alter or amend the total points as needed. All grades will be posted on Blackboard.*

Grading Scale

Final grades will be determined using the following grading scale:

A	90.0% – 100%	C	70.0% – 76.9%
B+	87.0% – 89.9%	D+	67.0% – 69.9%
B	80.0% – 86.9%	D	60.0% – 66.9%
C+	77.0% – 79.9%	F	0.00% – 59.9%

****Do not request your grade be rounded up at the end of the semester***

USI Internship and Career Fair Participation
As a class, we will participate in USI's Internship and Career Fair for a formal class assignment, an event offered each semester and sponsored by USI's Career Success Center. See the date/time on your course schedule and ***plan early to attend (i.e., ask off work)*** since it does not always occur during our class period. You should plan on being at the fair at least one hour anytime during the fair's hours of operation. Details for this formal assignment will be distributed before the event, and we will prepare for it in class.

Extra Credit
One extra credit assignment will be offered this semester.

Communication Guidelines

Netiquette
All online class communication and interactions with other students, and the professor should follow common social standards for respect and courtesy. (see USI Netiquette Guidelines for Students for details)

Communication Expectation
Contact me with questions at cgilstrap@usi.edu – do not message me on Blackboard. Generally, I will respond within 2 business days. See the email policy section of the syllabus if you do not receive a response.

Professional Behavior and Respect for All
Our course moves students from casual communication to planned, polished, and professional communication skills. As part of that effort, students must demonstrate respect for all people associated with the course regardless of external factors.

Course Policies

Central Standard Time
Central Standard Time (CST) is used for all assignment and testing deadlines. Keep this in mind if you live in a different time zone.

Assignment Due Dates & Submissions
No late assignments will be accepted in the course. Additionally, no assignment will be reopened once its deadline has expired.

Assignments not turned in by the assigned date/time will receive a zero. If you know you will be absent on the day an assignment is due, submit it early. If you are absent when an in-class assignment is completed, you will receive a zero.

Students are responsible for submitting correct and complete files for assignments. Major assignments can be uploaded to Blackboard **unlimited times** until the due date/time. However, no additional submissions are allowed once the due date/time expires, including any situations which involve students submitting incorrect or incomplete files. Plan for technical and Internet delay issues when uploading documents before deadlines. The last submission uploaded before the due date/time is the one that will graded.

No assignments will be accepted via email.

Attendance
The value of this course is found in your active participation in class experiences. Thus, regular attendance and active participation is required during class. Attendance will be taken at the:

- beginning of every in-person class session
- beginning and/or end of every synchronous Zoom class session (if we have them)

To be counted as present, you need to arrive to class on time and not leave early. Excessive tardiness will be counted as absent.

You have 3 personal days (i.e., free absences) before points are deducted from your final grade, so use them wisely. Five points will be deducted from your final grade for every absence after the third absence.

Missed assignments, excluding chapter quizzes and the APA Mastery Exam, will be rescheduled **only under a documented emergency** and if every effort is made to notify me **in advance**. Documentation must be brought to me within 1 class period of returning to class. I reserve the right to authenticate all documentation, with or without assistance from the Dean of Students Office.

You must obtain any oral or written information from a peer who was present during the class period you were absent. Therefore, I recommend you get contact information from at least one peer early in the semester. An absence does not relieve you of obligations related to deadlines or assignment requirements, including those announced in the class period you are absent.

Required Viewing of Online Lectures/Videos
Students are **required to watch all Blackboard lectures and videos** by the due date/time listed on the class schedule. **No lecture or assignment video is optional** because each discusses class requirements and concepts you will apply in assignments and future deliverables.

All lectures will be watched in Blackboard's VoiceThread. You cannot fast forward videos or play them at double-speed, so plan accordingly. Additionally, do not forget to click the "Submit" button after watching the video or you will not receive a grade for watching the video.

Points are assigned for viewing each online lecture/video in its entirety. Points are all or nothing for each online lecture/video – no partial points will be assigned. Blackboard is set up to track if students watch required lectures/videos in their entirety.

Take notes as you watch each lecture/video, just like you would in a seated course. You will need to reference your notes throughout the semester. Information provided in lectures/videos is required for class assignments and is often not discussed beyond Blackboard lectures/videos.

Blackboard Comments
Most Blackboard grades will also include professor comments posted in the *Feedback to Learner* section with the grades. Make sure you **read ALL comments posted with ALL grades** since they impact future deliverables/experiences in our course, other academic settings, and the workplace. Do NOT only look at the numerical grade. Your professors can see if you have reviewed comments in Blackboard.

For help finding grades and feedback, see the *Blackboard Ulta Student Help* link located in the *USI Students Resources* section on Blackboard.

Readings
Your success in this class depends on closely reading all chapters, Blackboard directions, and assignment sheets. Remember, "skimming" is not synonymous with "reading."

To increase your engagement and retention with the textbook's chapter content, highlight, underline, and/or take notes while reading each chapter AND remove all distractions from your environment while reading. If you are renting your textbook, former students recommend taking notes and/or using Post-It notes to help you engage with the readings.

Honorlock Online Proctoring

Honorlock will be used as the online proctoring/anti-plagiarism tool for the chapter quizzes and APA Mastery Exam. It will record your computer screen and your surroundings, including yourself, while taking quizzes and the exam. Therefore, you:

- will need to use the Google Chrome browser
- must download the Honorlock Chrome Extension, and
- must have a webcam with a microphone when taking an online chapter quiz and the APA Mastery Exam

If you need privacy or a stable internet connection, Rice Library offers space with a computer for taking your proctored tests. There are rooms available during the Library's open hours on a first-come, first-served basis. You can reserve a room online up to 30 days in advance using the booking calendar.

- Please view instructions and tips on the Online Course Support Resources webpage.
- Honorlock offers 24/7 support. For live support and more information, visit Honorlock's Student Resources.

Reading Quizzes and Exams 1 & 2

Syllabus Quiz

You will complete a syllabus quiz that will be opened after our first class and due before our second class. The quiz will include 10 questions (true/false, multiple choice, 1/2 point each) and a 15-minute time limit, so make sure you **read closely before opening your quiz**. The **ONLY resource** you can use to take the quiz is your syllabus.

Chapter Reading Quizzes

Quizzes for our 12 textbook chapters will be administered on Blackboard to increase your engagement with the chapters as the semester progresses and prepare for our in-class application of textbook content. Additionally, they will serve as a study guide for the major exams in the course. Each chapter quiz will include 10 questions (true/false, multiple choice, 1/2 point each) and a 15-minute time limit, so make sure you **read closely before opening your quiz**. The **ONLY resources** you can use to take each quiz is your textbook and chapter notes. If you utilize an online version of our textbook during the quiz, it must show up on the **SAME monitor** you use to take the quiz. Honorlock will be used to confirm these requirements are followed. A zero will be assigned if you use AI or other unapproved resources (i.e., browsers, other people, websites) while taking each quiz. Grades will automatically be posted to Blackboard after completing a quiz. However, I reserve the right to change the grade after I review your Honorlock video. If AI and/or unapproved resources were utilized in any of your test-taking videos, you will receive a zero for that quiz.

I reserve the right to change the final grade for this assignment after I review ALL of your Honorlock videos. If AI and/or unapproved resources (i.e., websites, browsers, other people) were utilized in ANY of your test-taking videos, including ones where you did not meet the minimum number of correct items, you will receive a zero for the assignment even if you reached the 88 minimum score in one of your sessions.

Quizzes will include questions about the chapter's content, figures, illustrations, boxes, and information in the @ Work boxes.

Remember:

- You must use the Google Chrome browser
- Do not open your quiz until you are ready to take it (you cannot log out and log back in)
- You can only move forward once you start the quiz
- Do not hit the back button - it will knock you out and assign you the score you earned up until that point

- Only take your quiz where you have a reliable Internet connection (if it knocks you out, it assigns you the grade you earned up to that point)
    - If an Internet connection issue occurs, email me immediately
    - If I see a connection issue occurred, I will re-open your quiz
    - However, you are still required to take the quiz again, by the due date/time
- Each chapter quiz will disappear from Blackboard after its due date/time

Exam 1 and Exam 2

Two major exams will be administered in the semester. Each exam will cover six chapters. See your class schedule for exam dates and chapters. Both exams will be given in class during class time. No resources or technology can be used during the exam time. Bring a #2 pencil on exam days. If you are absent on an exam day, you will receive a zero for the exam (no make-ups will be given). The only exception is if you are a student athlete and must be absent for a USI-required event – evidence from USI is required to confirm this excuse.

Class Participation & Technology

You should come to each class PREPARED to critically discuss and apply the material listed on the schedule for that day. We will use in-class exercises to illustrate principles, so your absence will deprive you of this material. A warm body does not count as active participation in person. As a result, no ear buds/headphones can be worn in class, and all cell phones must be put away.

Email

Email is not answered on a 24/7 timeframe; instead, it is only answered during standard business hours. Additionally, it is answered in the order it is received. Please do not wait until the last minute to make requests or ask questions via email, as they may not be answered according to your time constraints.

It is your responsibility to **check your USI email daily** for class correspondence and announcements. **Think of it as your work email.** Moreover, as a business communication course, your email correspondence must follow the content and format requirements for a formal business email, which we will learn in class.

Below is the email policy for all BCOM 231 courses. It will not officially go into effect until we learn about business emails in class, however, it is important you know about it now. An appropriately formatted email does not have to be a long email, but it must include all required content and format requirements.

> *Email messages not composed as a **formal business email** (proper format, required content, grammar, mechanics, professionalism) will be deleted without response. Emails MUST include the required content and correct format for all of the following to receive a response:*
>
> - *an informative subject line*
> - *salutation*
> - *body*
> - *sentence of goodwill as a separate paragraph*
> - *complimentary closing*
> - *signature*
> - *signature block (this does not count as a signature)*
> - *appropriate editing/grammar/writing*
>
> *See Appendix A (Figure A.2) for the required format and content for a formal email message.*

If you do not receive a response from me within 2 business days, it may be because your original email did not meet the content/format requirements for a **formal business email**. If that is the case, resend your email using the correct format and content requirements for a formal business email.

Academic Integrity, AI Use Policy, and SafeAssign

Academic Integrity

Academic integrity is the hallmark of truth and honesty in an engaged university community. Students are expected to maintain complete honesty and integrity in academic experiences, both in and out of the classroom. Examples of academic dishonesty could include, but may not be limited to:

- using an assignment, or portions of an assignment, obtained from another student, course, or online
- turning in an assignment submitted in another course
- writing an assignment for another student
- cheating, using AI/unapproved resources or working with others on exams/quizzes

- using information from a source (i.e., direct quotes, paraphrasing) without providing a proper APA citation
- participating in academic sabotage, interference, or fabrication
- using unapproved AI generated content (see our course AI Use Policy)

Students found guilty of any breach of academic integrity will receive a zero for the assignment for the first offense. Second offenses will result in a failing grade for the course.

AI Use Policy

Artificial intelligence (AI) tools that generate text, images, code, and other content are widely available. You are not permitted to use AI tools that generate content (i.e., ChatGPT, DALL-E, Copilot, Claude, Gemini, Perplexity) for work produced in this class or while taking chapter quizzes or the APA Mastery Exam. Writing, analytical, and critical thinking skills are part of your learning outcomes in this course, and you must learn the fundamentals for future application. Although we will discuss the role of AI in business communication, all writing assignments must be prepared by you, the student. Content created by generative AI tools may not be considered your own original work.

This course assumes that work submitted by students (all process work, drafts, final versions, and all other submissions) will be generated by the students themselves. See the *Academic Integrity* policy for the outcomes if a student or team breaches the *AI Use Policy*.

The only exception in our class will be your use of Grammarly Pro to help you improve your original writing.

The *AI Use Policy* applies to all individual and team assignments. For team assignments, the entire team must closely edit deliverables to guarantee all team members have correctly followed the AI policy. If one team member uses AI to generate content in a submitted assignment, the entire team has breached the course *AI Use Policy* since it is a team deliverable. See the *Academic Integrity* section for additional details.

Resources will be used to assess AI generated content in submitted class assignments. If you are not sure about what academic dishonesty or plagiarism may be and what is acceptable use in this course and on specific assignments, contact me prior to the deliverable's deadline.

SafeAssign
You will regularly turn in assignments on SafeAssign, Blackboard's antiplagiarism site. According to SafeAssign (2022), the purpose of this system is to "prevent plagiarism, protect the originality of work, ensure a level playing field, and create awareness and educate students" (para. 1). Additionally, it effectively serves "as both a deterrent (i.e., reviews assignments for originality) and an educational tool (i.e., helps students properly attribute sources)" (SafeAssign, 2022, para. 3).

Changes to Course

I reserve the right to make changes to the schedule or other course details. Check Blackboard and your USI email daily for class updates.

Report Your Internship(s)

Report all current and future internships (paid or unpaid, credit or non-credit) completed while at USI on USI's Career Launch. Additional internship and co-op resources are found on USI's Career Success Center's website.

The Romain College of Business and USI's Career Success Center rely on your data to:

- track student internships
- connect with organizations currently working with interns
- help students identify internship opportunities recruit organizations for future internship opportunities

Additional Course and University Policies

Please become familiar with the policies and guidance on the following topics by reading the Course and University Policies (Syllabus Statements).

- Academic Continuity
- Academic Integrity
- AI Tools Use
- Civility and Non-Discrimination
- Course Materials Sharing and Recording
- Disability Accommodations
- Mental Health Resources: Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS)
- Online/Remote Proctoring Using Honorlock
- Safety: Emergency Evacuation and Shelter-in-place Instructions
- Safety: Medical Emergency - Automated External Defibrillators (AED)
- Student Basic Needs
- Title IX - Sexual Misconduct

Course Materials Sharing and Recordings

USI seeks to protect the integrity of what transpires during class sessions among students and the instructor, any course materials prepared by the instructor, and the privacy of students and faculty.

Course Materials Sharing
My lectures and course materials, including presentations, quizzes, exams, outlines, recordings/streaming, and similar materials, are protected by copyright. I am the exclusive owner of copyright in those materials I create. I encourage you to take notes and make copies of course materials for your own educational use. However, you may not, nor may you knowingly allow others to reproduce or distribute lecture notes and course materials publicly without my express written consent. This includes providing materials to commercial course material suppliers such as Course Hero, Chegg, and other similar services. Students who publicly distribute or display or help others publicly distribute or

display copies or modified copies of an instructor's course materials may be in violation of The Student Rights and Responsibilities: Code of Student Behavior. Similarly, you own copyright of your original deliverables produced in class. If I am interested in posting your deliverables, or a portion of them, on the course website, I will request your written permission.

Recording Class Sessions

You are not permitted to record (audio or video) any class activity, except in cases when the student has an approved accommodation from Disability Resources permitting the recording of class sessions for the student's personal educational purposes. In such cases, the accommodation letter must be presented to the instructor in advance of any recording being done, and all students in the course will be notified whenever recording will be taking place. You may not copy, publish, post, or redistribute audio or video recordings with anyone not in this class. Doing so would be a breach of the Code of Student Behavior, and, in some cases, a violation of the Federal Education Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) and copyright laws.

Syllabus Changes

The syllabus is a guide to the course and is subject to change with reasonable advanced notice as course needs arise.

Students Resources

- Academic Success Center and Writers' Room
- Rice Library
- Information Technology
- University Health Center
- Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS)
- Archie's Food Closet
- Romain College of Business Advising Center

Safety

Emergency Evacuation and Shelter-in-Place Instructions

- Maps for the evacuation or shelter-in-place is found by BEC elevators
- The quickest evacuation exit from this classroom is:
    - 2nd floor – one of the three stairways to the Quad
    - 1st floor – sliding door to the Quad
- Set up your Rave Alerts and be familiar with the USI Emergency Procedures

Medical Emergency - Automated External Defibrillators (AED)

Automated External Defibrillators (AEDs) are life-saving devices used during sudden cardiac arrest to restore a normal heart rhythm. AEDs are strategically placed in campus buildings to ensure quick access during medical emergencies.

- The closest AED location to this classroom is next to the 1st floor elevators by the Quad's sliding door entrance.
- View the map of AEDs on campus and medical emergencies information.

Tentative Course Outline and Schedule

Week	Topic(s)	Readings and Exams
1	• Introductions • Email Signature Blocks	• Syllabus
2	• Developing Your Professional Presence • Managing the Communication Process	• Chapters 1 & 3
3	• Communicating Your Professional Brand	• Chapter 12
4	• Communicating Your Professional Brand • Communicating Persuasively	• Chapter 5
5	• Internship & Career Fairs	
6	• Communicating Routine Messages & Building Goodwill	• Chapter 4
7	• Communicating Bad News • APA Writing Style	• Chapter 6
8	• APA Writing Style	• Exam 1
9	• *No Class – Spring Break*	
10	• Finding & Evaluating Business Information • Preparing Business Reports • Working with Others & Groupthink	• Chapters 8, 10, & 2
11	• Preparing & Delivering Business Presentations	• Chapter 11
12	• Preparing Business Proposals • Using Social Media in Business	• Chapters 9 & 7
13	• Text Analytics Project	• Exam 2
14	• Text Analytics Project	
15	• Text Analytics Project	
16	• Text Analytics Presentations	• Text Analytics Presentations
	• Finals Week	

I reserve the right to change the syllabus based on course needs. When such changes are made, students will be informed with reasonable advanced notice.